



Rift DEEPENS

The President finds himself in a hard place as his party and the army begin to challenge him

| By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi |

Nobody expected it to be smooth sailing for President Asif Zardari. Apart from having to live down a tainted past, he knew even as he took office that Pakistan faced some of the biggest challenges in recent history—politically, economically, socially and geo-strategically. But the speed at which Zardari's graph has plummeted has left most observers stunned; the shortest "honeymoon" in Pakistan's history.

According to a poll conducted by the International Republican Institute before the Mumbai attacks, 88 per cent of Pakistanis think the country is headed in the wrong direction, while 65 per cent disapprove of the President. Zardari already faced serious security risks after the assassination of Benazir Bhutto, which only multiplied once he became President and the leader of a ruling party perceived to be even more hand-in-glove with the Americans than General Pervez Musharraf. These have seen Zardari become almost a prisoner inside the presidency. He hardly ventures out and has spent almost half his tenure on official and personal trips outside the country. But surprisingly, the biggest challenge to him so far has come from within his own party.

Rumours of tension between the President and his party's own parliamentary leader, Prime Minister Yousuf Raza Gilani, had been doing the rounds for a few weeks. But these burst out into the open on January 7, when Gilani summarily sacked the National Security Adviser (NSA), Major General (retd) Mahmud Ali Durrani, without consulting Zardari. The reason provided was that Durrani had released a statement confirming Mumbai terrorist Ajmal Amir Kasab's Pakistani nationality without taking Gilani into confidence. Observers, however, think the sacking had more to do with Gilani asserting his independence.

Gilani had been smarting at playing second fiddle to Zardari and being perceived as a kind of rubber-stamp prime minister in the mould of former premier Shaukat Aziz. Since Zardari continued to lead the party as well as enjoy the powers of the presidency that Musharraf had imbued the office with, most people—including foreign diplomats—who understood where the real power lay, simply bypassed the prime minister.

Many key bureaucrats—including Durrani—had been appointed directly by Zardari, even though they were supposed to report to the prime minister. Gilani first indicated that he would not continue to accept the status quo when he replaced Siraj Shamsuddin, a close Zardari confidant, as his principal secretary. But Durrani's sacking garnered much more attention, particularly because it became conflated with the Mumbai attacks issue and because Durrani was also considered close to the US establishment. The seriousness of the rift—denied by both the presidency and the prime minister himself—can